TEACHER GUIDE

AQA GCSE Business (8132)

Organisational structures

3.4 Human resources
3.4.1 Organisational structures



A revision lesson. Pupils run a car dealership in firms of four and revise organisational structures on their own deals. Seat each firm together. Each firm answers the topic tasks together.

The lesson

45-minute setting

Setup	Round 1	Round 2	Round 3	Final questions

EVERY ROUND

Firm decisions
3 min

→

Deals
4½–5 min

→

Topic tasks
4 min

→

B2B deal
2½ min
from Round 2

LESSON SETTINGS

30 min	45 min	60 min	75 min

What pupils do

Every pupil buys and sells cars. In Firm decisions, each role has its own job.



CEO

Staff · Sabotage from Round 2



Finance

Capital & Loans · Investments



Sales & Marketing

Marketing



Operations

Seasonal stock

Topic tasks

Each firm gets its own figures. The method is the same.

1 Too wide a span

Round 1

Your sales manager leads 15 staff and has no time to coach the new ones.

Which change would help most?

- **A** Widen the span of control further
- **B** Move all decisions to head office
- **C** Remove the sales manager's post
- **D** Add a team leader for some staff

ANSWER

✓ Add a team leader for some staff

Why: A narrower span gives each manager time for each worker.

2 Flatter structure

Round 1

You remove a layer of managers.

Which two effects are most likely?

- **A** Narrower spans of control
- **B** Closer supervision of staff
- **C** More chances of promotion
- **D** Lower management costs
- **E** Messages travel faster

ANSWER

✓ Lower management costs
✓ Messages travel faster

Why: Fewer layers: quicker messages and fewer managers to pay, but wider spans.

3 Chain of command

Round 2

A salesperson's idea goes up the chain of command.

Put the route in order, first to last?

- **A** The sales team leader
- **B** The branch manager
- **C** The managing director
- **D** The salesperson

ANSWER

1. The salesperson
2. The sales team leader
3. The branch manager
4. The managing director

Why: The chain of command runs from the bottom of the structure to the top.

Topic tasks

4 Delayering saving

Round 2

You remove a layer of supervisors.

Yearly saving in pay?

Supervisors removed	**5 staff**
Pay of each, a year	**£22,500**
Managers who take their staff	**3 staff**
Pay rise for each manager	**£3,000**

ANSWER

£103,500

5 × £22,500 − 3 × £3,000 = £103,500

Why: Delayering cuts pay costs, but each manager now leads more staff.

5 Who sets prices

Round 3

Head office sets every branch's prices. One branch keeps losing sales to a cheaper local rival.

What should you change, and why?

A Let the branch set its prices

B Keep all pricing at head office

ANSWER

✓ Let the branch set its prices

Why: The manager who knows local buyers can react faster.

6 Tall structure

Round 3

Your firm has six layers, and each manager has only three staff.

Which problem is most likely?

A Too few chances of promotion

B Staff given too much freedom

C Managers too busy to supervise

D Slow decisions through many layers

ANSWER

✓ Slow decisions through many layers

Why: Narrow spans make a tall structure, so messages pass many people.

Final questions

Each pupil answers 6 final questions on organisational structures. They come from these 7 questions.

1 Tall means many levels; flat, few. Worked case: a six-level chain takes a week to decide a branch request. A group cuts two of five levels. Gain and cost?
✔ **Faster decisions, but fewer promotion steps and less supervision**

2 A dealer group has six levels from technician to chief executive. Which type of structure is this?
✔ **A tall (hierarchical) structure**

3 What is an advantage of a flat structure for a small dealership?
✔ **Messages pass quickly between staff and the owner**

4 What is a drawback of a tall structure for a national dealer group?
✔ **Decisions take longer to pass down the levels**

5 What does an organisation chart of a dealership show?
✔ **Who reports to whom in the business**

6 A dealer group removes its layer of regional managers. What is the most likely effect?
✔ **Branch managers report straight to head office**

7 An organisation chart shows a chief executive, 3 managers under her and 5 staff under each manager. How many people are on the chart?
✔ **19 people**